Saraswati be best known today as the benign and beloved goddess of learning and the arts, the consort of Brahma no less, most often portrayed seated on a lotus flower and strumming the sitar-like instrument known as a *vina*? Her riverine origins barely get a look-in – except in those circles where the Saraswati River plays a central role in the 'out of India' thesis.

One of the last of the books of the *R-V* to be composed is Book 10, by which time it is the Indus River, under its ancient name of Sindhu, that is being celebrated as the mightiest of all rivers. The Saraswati is now just one of ten lesser rivers and its qualities have greatly diminished. And as the centuries pass so the Saraswati's manifestations continue to diminish. By the time the *Panchvimsha Brahmana* in the *Sama-Veda* has been composed, in about 800 BCE, the Saraswati is no longer able to hold up the heavens and consequently has gone underground.[22] And when the great epic of the *Mahabharata* first began to be assembled soon after that date the river is described as fragmented, disappearing and reappearing, having been commanded by a sage named Utatha to disappear into the sands and to desert the land.

And yet all the while the Saraswati continues to be honoured as the fountainhead of the Arya's homeland, and in the code of laws known as the *Manusmriti*, or 'Laws of Manu', written no earlier than the third century BCE, this homeland is declared to be bordered by the Saraswati on one side and by a second river known as the Drishadwati on the other.

One of the first Western scholars to attempt to locate this homeland was Horace Wilson. In the introduction to his translation of the *Vishnu Purana* Wilson identified the Saraswati and Drishadwati as two minor rivers of the Punjab. 'The holy land of Manu,' he wrote, 'lies between the